

PRELUDES

BY  
ALICE  
CHRISTIANA  
G. MEYNELL

ILLUSTRATED  
BY  
ELIZABETH  
THOMPSON

# PRELUDES

BY  
ALICE CHRISTIANA G. MEYNELL



ILLUSTRATED BY  
ELIZABETH THOMPSON



PRELUDES

BY  
ALICE  
CHRISTIANA  
G. MEYNELL

ILLUSTRATED  
BY  
ELIZABETH  
THOMPSON

# PRELUDES

BY  
ALICE CHRISTIANA G. MEYNELL



ILLUSTRATED BY  
ELIZABETH THOMPSON

## **The Project Gutenberg eBook of Preludes**

This eBook is for the use of anyone anywhere in the United States and most other parts of the world at no cost and with almost no restrictions whatsoever. You may copy it, give it away or re-use it under the terms of the Project Gutenberg License included with this eBook or online at [www.gutenberg.org](http://www.gutenberg.org). If you are not located in the United States, you will have to check the laws of the country where you are located before using this eBook.

Title: Preludes

Author: Alice Meynell

Illustrator: Elizabeth Butler

Release date: August 19, 2026 [eBook #79402]

Language: English

Original publication: London: Henry S. King, 1875

Other information and formats: [www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/79402](http://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/79402)

Credits: Richard Tonsing and the Online Distributed Proofreading Team at <https://www.pgdp.net> (This file was produced from images generously made available by The Internet Archive)

\*\*\* START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK PRELUDES \*\*\*

**Transcriber's Note:**

New original cover art included with this eBook is granted to the public domain.

## ***PRELUDES.***





*Frontispiece.*

# PRELUDES.

BY  
A. C. THOMPSON.

*WITH ILLUSTRATIONS AND ORNAMENTS BY*  
ELIZABETH THOMPSON.



HENRY S. KING & CO.,  
65, CORNHILL, AND 12, PATERNOSTER ROW, LONDON,  
1875.



*(All rights reserved.)*

TO  
MY FATHER AND MOTHER.





## **CONTENTS.**

|                                                  | <b>PAGE</b>               |
|--------------------------------------------------|---------------------------|
| IN EARLY SPRING                                  | <a href="#"><u>1</u></a>  |
| PARTED                                           | <a href="#"><u>3</u></a>  |
| TO A POET                                        | <a href="#"><u>5</u></a>  |
| SONG OF THE SPRING TO THE SUMMER                 | <a href="#"><u>8</u></a>  |
| TO THE BELOVED                                   | <a href="#"><u>10</u></a> |
| MEDITATION                                       | <a href="#"><u>12</u></a> |
| TO THE BELOVED DEAD                              | <a href="#"><u>13</u></a> |
| SONNET                                           | <a href="#"><u>15</u></a> |
| IN AUTUMN                                        | <a href="#"><u>16</u></a> |
| A LETTER FROM A GIRL TO HER OWN OLD AGE          | <a href="#"><u>19</u></a> |
| SONG                                             | <a href="#"><u>23</u></a> |
| PYGMALION                                        | <a href="#"><u>25</u></a> |
| BUILDERS OF RUINS                                | <a href="#"><u>27</u></a> |
| SONNET                                           | <a href="#"><u>31</u></a> |
| SONG OF THE DAY TO THE NIGHT                     | <a href="#"><u>32</u></a> |
| “SOEUR MONIQUE”                                  | <a href="#"><u>34</u></a> |
| SONNET                                           | <a href="#"><u>40</u></a> |
| A TRYST THAT FAILED                              | <a href="#"><u>41</u></a> |
| SONNET. THOUGHTS IN SEPARATION                   | <a href="#"><u>43</u></a> |
| REGRETS                                          | <a href="#"><u>44</u></a> |
| SONG                                             | <a href="#"><u>46</u></a> |
| SONNET. IN FEBRUARY                              | <a href="#"><u>47</u></a> |
| SAN LORENZO GIUSTINIANI’S MOTHER                 | <a href="#"><u>48</u></a> |
| THE POETS                                        | <a href="#"><u>50</u></a> |
| SONNET. THE LOVE OF NARCISSUS                    | <a href="#"><u>53</u></a> |
| TO A LOST MELODY                                 | <a href="#"><u>54</u></a> |
| SONNET. AT A POET’S GRAVE                        | <a href="#"><u>57</u></a> |
| SONNET. THE POET TO NATURE                       | <a href="#"><u>58</u></a> |
| THE POET TO HIS CHILDHOOD                        | <a href="#"><u>59</u></a> |
| SONNET. TO ——                                    | <a href="#"><u>63</u></a> |
| AN UNMARKED FESTIVAL                             | <a href="#"><u>64</u></a> |
| SONNET. A YOUNG CONVERT                          | <a href="#"><u>66</u></a> |
| SONNET. SPRING ON THE ALBAN HILLS                | <a href="#"><u>67</u></a> |
| SONG OF THE NIGHT AT DAYBREAK                    | <a href="#"><u>69</u></a> |
| SONNET. TO A DAISY                               | <a href="#"><u>70</u></a> |
| SONNET. TO ONE POEM IN A SILENT TIME             | <a href="#"><u>71</u></a> |
| A STUDY: IN THREE MONOLOGUES, WITH INTERRUPTIONS | <a href="#"><u>72</u></a> |

# **PRELUDES.**

## IN EARLY SPRING.

L'océan connu, l'âme reste à sonder.

VICTOR HUGO.

O Spring, I know thee! Seek for sweet surprise  
In the young children's eyes.  
But I have learnt the years, and know the yet  
Leaf-folded violet.  
Mine ear, awake to silence, can foretell  
The cuckoo's fitful bell.  
I wander in a grey time that encloses  
June and the wild hedge-roses.  
A year's procession of the flowers doth pass  
My feet, along the grass.  
And all you sweet birds silent yet, I know  
The notes that stir you so,  
Your songs yet half devised in the dim dear  
Beginnings of the year.  
In these young days you meditate your part;  
I have it all by heart.  
I know the secrets of the seeds of flowers  
Hidden, and warm with showers,  
And how, in kindling Spring, the cuckoo shall  
Alter his interval.  
But not a flower or song I ponder is  
My own, but memory's.  
I shall be silent in those days desired  
Before a world inspired.  
O dear brown birds, compose your old song-phrases,



Earth, thy familiar daisies.

The poet mused upon the dusky height,  
    Between the stars towards night,  
His purpose in his heart. I watched, a space,  
    The meaning of his face;  
There was the secret, fled from earth and skies,  
    Hid in his grey young eyes.  
My heart and all the Summer wait his choice,  
    And wonder for his voice.  
Who shall foretell his songs, and who aspire  
    But to divine his lyre?  
Sweet earth, we know thy dimmest mysteries,  
    But he is lord of his.

## PARTED.

Come vedi, ancor non m' abbandona.

DANTE.

Farewell to one now silenced quite,  
Sent out of hearing, out of sight,—  
My friend of friends, whom I shall miss.  
He is not banished, though, for this,—  
Nor he, nor sadness, nor delight.

Though I shall walk with him no more,  
A low voice sounds upon the shore.  
He must not watch my resting-place  
But who shall drive a mournful face  
From the sad winds about my door?

I shall not hear his voice complain,  
But who shall stop the patient rain?  
His tears must not disturb my heart,  
But who shall change the years, and part  
The world from every thought of pain?

Although my life is left so dim,  
The morning crowns the mountain-brim;  
Joy is not gone from summer skies,  
Nor innocence from children's eyes,  
And all these things are part of him.

He is not banished, for the showers

Yet wake this green warm earth of ours.  
How can the summer but be sweet?  
I shall not have him at my feet,  
And yet my feet are on the flowers.



## TO A POET.

Thou who singest through the earth,  
All the earth's wild creatures fly thee.  
Everywhere thou marrest mirth.

    Dumbly they defy thee.  
There is something they deny thee.

Pines thy fallen nature ever  
For the unfallen Nature sweet.  
But she shuns thy long endeavour,  
    Though her flowers and wheat  
Throng and press thy pausing feet.

Though thou tame a bird to love thee,  
Press thy face to grass and flowers,  
All these things reserve above thee  
    Secrets in the bowers,  
Secrets in the sun and showers.

Sing thy sorrow, sing thy gladness.  
In thy songs must wind and tree  
Bear the fictions of thy sadness,  
    Thy humanity.  
For their truth is not for thee.

Wait, and many a secret nest,  
Many a hoarded winter-store  
Will be hidden on thy breast.  
    Things thou longest for

Will not fear or shun thee more.

Thou shalt intimately lie  
In the roots of flowers that thrust  
Upwards from thee to the sky,  
            With no more distrust,  
When they blossom from thy dust.

Silent labours of the rain  
Shall be near thee, reconciled;  
Little lives of leaves and grain,  
            All things shy and wild  
Tell thee secrets, quiet child.

Earth, set free from thy fair fancies  
And the art thou shalt resign,  
Will bring forth her rue and pansies  
            Unto more divine  
Thoughts than any thoughts of thine.

Nought will fear thee, humbled creature.  
There will lie thy mortal burden  
Pressed unto the heart of Nature,  
            Songless in a garden,  
With a long embrace of pardon.

Then the truth all creatures tell,  
And His will whom thou entreatest,  
Shall absorb thee; there shall dwell  
            Silence, the completest  
Of thy poems, last, and sweetest.



# SONG OF THE SPRING TO THE SUMMER.

## THE POET SINGS TO HER POET.

I miei desiri  
Che ti menavano.

DANTE.

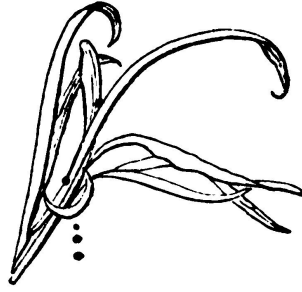
O poet of the time to be,  
My conqueror, I began for thee.  
Enter into thy poet's pain,  
And take the riches of the rain,  
And make the perfect year for me.

Thou unto whom my lyre shall fall,  
Whene'er thou comest, hear my call.  
Oh, keep the promise of my lays,  
Take the sweet parable of my days;  
I trust thee with the aim of all.

And if thy thoughts unfold from me,  
Know that I too have hints of thee,  
Dim hopes that come across my mind,  
In the rare days of warmer wind,  
And tones of summer in the sea.

And I have set thy paths, I guide  
Thy blossoms on the wild hill-side.  
And I, thy bygone poet, share  
The flowers that throng thy feet, where'er  
I led thy feet before I died.





## TO THE BELOVED.

A qui j'ai dit: "Toujours!" et qui m'a dit: "Partout!"

VICTOR HUGO.

Oh, not more subtly silence strays  
Amongst the winds, between the voices,  
Mingling alike with pensive lays,  
And with the music that rejoices,  
Than thou art present in my days.

My silence, life returns to thee  
In all the pauses of her breath.  
Hush back to rest the melody  
That out of thee awakeneth;  
And thou, wake ever, wake for me.

Full, full is life in hidden places,  
For thou art silence unto me.  
Full, full is thought in endless spaces.  
Full is my life. A silent sea  
Lies round all shores with long embraces.

Thou art like silence all unvexed  
Though wild words part my soul from thee.  
Thou art like silence unperplexed,  
A secret and a mystery  
Between one footfall and the next.

Most dear pause in a mellow lay!

Thou art inwoven with every air.  
With thee the wildest tempests play,  
And snatches of thee everywhere  
Make little heavens throughout a day.

Darkness and solitude shine, for me.  
For life's fair outward part are rife  
The silver noises; let them be.  
It is the very soul of life  
Listens for thee, listens for thee.

O pause between the sobs of cares!  
O thought within all thought that is;  
Trance between laughters unawares!  
Thou art the form of melodies,  
And thou the ecstasy of prayers.

## MEDITATION.

Rorate Cœli desuper, et nubes pluant Justum.  
Aperiatur Terra, et germinet Salvatorem.

No sudden thing of glory and fear  
Was the Lord's coming; but the dear  
Slow Nature's days followed each other  
To form the Saviour from his Mother  
—One of the children of the year.

The earth, the rain, received the trust,  
—The sun and dews, to frame the Just.  
He drew his daily life from these,  
Obedient to his own decrees,  
Who makes man from the fertile dust.

Sweet summer and the winter wild,  
These brought him forth, the Undefined.  
The happy Springs renewed again  
His daily bread, the golden grain,  
The food and raiment of the Child.

## TO THE BELOVED DEAD. A LAMENT.

Beloved, thou art like a tune that idle fingers  
    Play on a window-pane.  
The time is there, the form of music lingers;  
    But O thou sweetest strain,  
Where is thy soul? Thou liest i' the wind and rain.

Even as to him who plays that idle air,  
    It seems a melody,  
For his own soul is full of it, so, my Fair,  
    Dead, thou dost live in me,  
And all this lonely soul is full of thee.

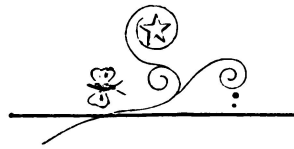
Thou song of songs!—not music as before  
    Unto the outward ear;  
My spirit sings thee inly evermore,  
    Thy falls with tear on tear.  
I fail for thee, thou art too sweet, too dear.

Thou silent song, thou ever voiceless rhyme,  
    Is there no pulse to move thee,  
At windy dawn, with a wild heart beating time,  
    And falling tears above thee,  
O music stifled from the ears that love thee?

Oh, for a strain of thee from outer air!  
    Soul wearies soul, I find.  
Of thee, thee, thee, I am mournfully aware,

—Contained in one poor mind,  
Who wert in tune and time to every wind.

Poor grave, poor lost belovèd! but I burn  
For some more vast To be.  
As he that played that bootless tune may turn  
And strike it on a lyre triumphantly,  
I wait some future, all one lyre for thee.



## SONNET.

Your own fair youth, you care so little for it,  
Smiling towards Heaven, you would not stay the advances  
Of time and change upon your happiest fancies.  
I keep your golden hour, and will restore it.

If ever, in time to come, you would explore it—  
Your old self whose thoughts went like last year's pansies,  
Look unto me; no mirror keeps its glances;  
In my unfailing praises now I store it.

To keep all joys of yours from Time's estranging,  
I shall be then a treasury where your gay  
Happy and pensive past for ever is.

I shall be then a garden charmed from changing,  
In which your June has never passed away.  
Walk there awhile among my memories.

## IN AUTUMN.

In ramo più non può foglia tenersi.

LORENZO DE'MEDICI.

Alors je te plaindrai, pauvre âme.

VICTOR HUGO.

The leaves are many under my feet,  
And drift one way.  
Their scent of death is weary and sweet.  
A flight of them is in the grey  
Where sky and forest meet.

The low winds moan for dead sweet years;  
The birds sing all for pain,  
Of a common thing, to weary ears,—  
Only a summer's fate of rain,  
And a woman's fate of tears.

I walk to love and life alone  
Over these mournful places,  
Across the summer overthrown,  
The dead joys of these silent faces,  
To claim my own.

I know his heart has beat to bright  
Sweet loves gone by.  
I know the leaves that die to-night  
Once budded to the sky,  
And I shall die to his delight.



O leaves, so quietly ending now,  
    You have heard cuckoos sing.  
And I will grow upon my bough  
    If only for a Spring,  
And fall when the rain is on my brow.

O tell me, tell me ere you die,  
    Is it worth the pain?  
You bloomed so fair, you waved so high;  
    Now that the sad days wane,  
Are you repenting where you lie?

I lie amongst you, and I kiss  
    Your fragrance mouldering.  
O dead delights, is it such bliss,  
    That tuneful Spring?  
Is love so sweet, that comes to this?

O dying blisses of the year,  
    I hear the young lamb bleat,  
The clamouring birds i' the copse I hear,  
    I hear the waving wheat,  
Together laid on a dead-leaf bier.

Kiss me again as I kiss you;  
    Kiss me again;  
For all your tuneful nights of dew,  
    In this your time of rain,  
For all your kisses when Spring was new.

You will not, broken hearts; let be.  
    I pass across your death  
To a golden summer you shall not see,  
    And in your dying breath  
There is no benison for me.

There is an Autumn yet to wane,  
    There are leaves yet to fall,

Which when I kiss, may kiss again,  
And, pitied, pity me all for all,  
And love me in mist and rain.



# A LETTER FROM A GIRL TO HER OWN OLD AGE.

Lete vedrai.

DANTE.

Listen, and when thy hand this paper presses,  
O time-worn woman, think of her who blesses  
What thy thin fingers touch, with her caresses.

O mother, for a weight of years do break thee!  
O daughter, for slow time must yet awake thee,  
And from the changes of my heart must make thee.

O fainting traveller, morn is grey in heaven.  
Dost thou remember how the clouds were driven?  
And are they calm about the fall of even?

Pause near the ending of thy long migration,  
For this one sudden hour of desolation  
Appeals to one hour of thy meditation.

Suffer, O silent one, that I remind thee  
Of the great hills that storm the sky behind thee,  
Of the wild winds of power that have resigned thee.

Know that the mournful plain where thou must wander,  
Is but a grey and silent world, but ponder  
The misty mountains of the morning yonder.

Listen; the mountain winds with rain were fretting,  
And sudden gleams the mountain-tops besetting.  
I cannot let thee fade to death, forgetting.

What part of this wild heart of mine I know not  
Will follow with thee where the great winds blow not,  
And where the young flowers of the mountain grow not.

Yet let my letter with thy lost thoughts in it  
Tell what the way was when thou didst begin it,  
And win with thee the goal when thou shalt win it.

Oh, in some hour of thine my thoughts shall guide thee.  
Suddenly, though time, darkness, silence hide thee,  
This wind from thy lost country flits beside thee;

Telling thee: all thy memories moved the maiden,  
With thy regrets was morning over-shaden,  
With sorrow thou hast left, her life was laden.

But whither shall my thoughts turn to pursue thee?  
Life changes, and the years and days renew thee.  
Oh, Nature brings my straying heart unto thee.

Her winds will join us, with their constant kisses  
Upon the evening as the morning tresses,  
Her summers breathe the same unchanging blisses.

And we, so altered in our shifting phases,  
Track one another 'mid the many mazes  
By the eternal child-breath of the daisies.

I have not writ this letter of divining  
To make a glory of thy silent pining.  
A triumph of thy mute and strange declining.

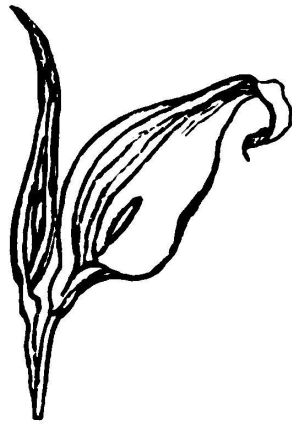
Only one youth, and the bright life was shrouded.  
Only one morning, and the day was clouded.

And one old age with all regrets is crowded.

Oh, hush; oh, hush! Thy tears my words are steeping.  
Oh, hush, hush, hush! So full, the fount of weeping?  
Poor eyes, so quickly moved, so near to sleeping?

Pardon the girl; such strange desires beset her.  
Poor woman, lay aside the mournful letter  
That breaks thy heart; the one that wrote, forget her.

The one that now thy faded features guesses,  
With filial fingers thy grey hair caresses,  
With morning tears thy mournful twilight blesses.



## SONG.

As the inhastening tide doth roll,  
Dear and desired, upon the whole  
Long shining strand, and floods the caves,  
Your love comes filling with happy waves  
The open sea-shore of my soul.

But inland from the seaward spaces,  
None knows, not even you, the places  
Brimmed, at your coming, out of sight,  
—The little solitudes of delight  
This tide constrains in dim embraces.

You see the happy shore, wave-rimmed,  
But know not of the quiet dimmed  
Rivers your coming floods and fills,  
The little pools 'mid happier hills,  
My silent rivulets, over-brimmed.

What, I have secrets from you? Yes.  
But O my Sea, your love doth press  
And reach in further than you know,  
And fills all these; and when you go,  
There's loneliness in loneliness.



# PYGMALION.

## THE POET TO HIS POETRY.

There is no body without its spirit or genius.—EMERSON.

Thou art to live; I am watching thee.  
I have laid my patient chisel away,  
And watch thee somewhat wearily.  
How do I know what the mouth will say?  
How do I know what the eyes will be,

—What they must be? for I suppose  
The brows I made (white brows so blind),  
The lovely eyelids that I chose,  
Lending my hand to my inner mind,  
One certain colour must enclose.

I know not what the voice will sing.  
I only made the quiet breast,  
And white throat with much labouring.  
I only wrought and thought my best,  
And lo, a new voice shall out-ring.

God knows, and knew it, fast locked in  
By my own hand, who knew it not.  
Have I not made the little chin,  
This face and dear mouth, and begot  
The voice that needs must tune within?

I am blind, I am deaf, who wrought them so,



Who loved them so. This growing one  
Hath her own future there. Ah, woe!  
I hardly guess what I have done.  
More is gone from me than I know.

I claim the unguessed mysteries  
Which make this cold white figure warm.  
*My life!* Child, did I not devise  
In dreams thy dreams, carving thy form  
—Thy secrets, when I made thine eyes?

God knows. I chiselled each cold limb  
With loyal pain. He has given my mind  
Less light than my true hand; but dim  
Is life. I wait all I shall find,  
And all that I shall know, in Him.

## BUILDERS OF RUINS.

We build with strength the deep tower-wall  
That shall be shattered thus and thus.  
And fair and great are court and hall,  
But *how* fair—this is not for us,  
Who dimly feel the want of all.

We know, we know how all too bright  
All hues of ours though dimmed through tears,  
And how the marble gleams too white;—  
We speak in unknown tongues, the years  
Interpret everything aright,

And crown with weeds our pride of towers,  
And warm our marble through with sun,  
And break our pavements through with flowers  
With an Amen when all is done,  
Knowing these perfect things of ours.

O days, we ponder, left alone,  
Like children in their lonely hour,  
And in our secrets keep your own,  
As seeds the colour of the flower.  
To-day they are not all unknown,

The stars that 'twixt the rise and fall,  
Like relic-seers, shall one by one  
Stand musing o'er our empty hall;  
And setting moons shall brood upon

The frescoes of our inward wall.

And when some midsummer shall be,  
Hither will come some little one  
(Dusty with bloom of flowers is he),  
Sit on a ruin i' the late long sun,  
And think, one foot upon his knee.

And where they wrought, these lives of ours,  
So many-worded, many-souled,  
A North-west wind will take the towers,  
And dark with colour, sunny and cold,  
Will range alone among the flowers.

And here or there, at our desire,  
The little clamorous owl shall sit  
Through her still time; and we aspire  
To make a law (and know not it)  
Unto the life of a wild briar.

We have a perfect purpose, dear,  
Though from our consciousness 'tis hidden.  
Thou, time to come, shalt make it clear,  
Undoing our work; we are children chidden  
With pity, and smiles of many a year.

Who shall allot the praise, and guess  
What part is yours and what is ours?—  
O years that certainly will bless  
Our flowers with fruits, our seeds with flowers,  
With ruin all our perfectness.

Be patient, Time, of our delays,  
Too happy hopes, and wasted fears,  
Our faithful ways, our wilful ways.  
Solace our labours, O our seers  
The seasons, and our bards the days;

And make our pause and silence brim  
With the shrill children's play, and sweets  
Of those pathetic flowers and dim,  
Of those eternal flowers my Keats  
Dying felt growing over him.



## SONNET.

Senza te son nulla.

PETRARCA.

I touched the heart that loved me as a player  
Touches a lyre; content with my poor skill  
No touch save mine knew my beloved (and still  
I thought at times: Is there no sweet lost air

Old loves could wake in him, I cannot share?);  
Oh, he alone, alone could so fulfil  
My thoughts in sound to the measure of my will.  
He is dead, and silence takes me unaware.

The songs I knew not he resumes, set free  
From my constraining love, alas for me!  
His part in our tune goes with him; my part

Is locked in me for ever; I stand as mute  
As one with full strong music in his heart  
Whose fingers stray upon a shattered lute.

## **SONG OF THE DAY TO THE NIGHT.**

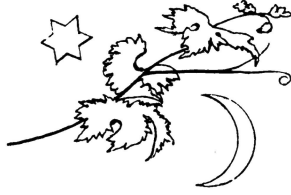
### **THE POET SINGS TO HIS POET.**

From dawn to dusk, and from dusk to dawn,  
We two are sundered always, sweet.  
A few stars shake o'er the rocky lawn  
And the cold sea-shore when we meet.  
The twilight comes with thy shadowy feet.

We are not day and night, my Fair,  
But one. It is an hour of hours.  
And thoughts that are not otherwhere  
Are thought here 'mid the blown sea-flowers,  
This meeting and this dusk of ours.

Delight has taken Pain to her heart,  
And there is dusk and stars for these.  
Oh, linger, linger! They would not part;  
And the wild wind comes from over-seas  
With a new song to the olive trees.

And when we meet by the sounding pine  
Sleep draws near to his dreamless brother.  
And when thy sweet eyes answer mine,  
Peace nestles close to her mournful mother,  
And Hope and Weariness kiss each other.



**“SOEUR MONIQUE.”**  
**A RONDEAU BY COUPERIN.**

Quiet form of silent nun,  
What has given you to my inward eyes?  
What has marked you, unknown one,  
In the throngs of centuries  
That mine ears do listen through?  
This old master's melody  
That expresses you,  
This admired simplicity,  
Tender, with a serious wit,  
And two words, the name of it,  
“Soeur Monique.”

And if sad the music is,  
It is sad with mysteries  
Of a small immortal thing  
That the passing ages sing,—  
Simple music making mirth  
Of the dying and the birth  
Of the people of the earth.

No, not sad; we are beguiled,  
Sad with living as we are;  
Ours the sorrow, outpouring  
Sad self on a selfless thing,  
As our eyes and hearts are mild  
With our sympathy for Spring,



With a pity sweet and wild  
For the innocent and far,  
With our sadness in a star,  
Or our sadness in a child.

But two words, and this sweet air.

        Soeur Monique,  
Had he more, who set you there?  
Was his music-dream of you  
Of some perfect nun he knew,  
Or of some ideal, as true?

And I see you where you stand  
With your life held in your hand  
As a rosary of days.  
And your thoughts in calm arrays,  
And your innocent prayers are told  
On your rosary of days.  
And the young days and the old  
With their quiet prayers did meet  
When the chaplet was complete.

Did it vex you, the surmise  
Of this wind of words, this storm of cries,  
    Though you kept the silence so  
    In the storms of long ago,  
    And you keep it, like a star?  
    —Of the evils triumphing,  
Strong, for all your perfect conquering,  
    Silenced conqueror that you are?  
And I wonder at your peace, I wonder.  
Would it trouble you to know,  
O sweet soul, the world and sin  
By your calm feet trodden under  
    Long ago,  
Living now, mighty to win?  
And your feet are vanished like the snow.

Vanished; but the poet, he  
In whose dream your face appears,  
He who ranges unknown years  
With your music in his heart,  
Speaks to you familiarly  
Where you keep apart,  
And invents you as you were.  
And your picture, oh, my nun,  
Is a strangely easy one,  
For the holy weed you wear,  
For your hidden eyes and hidden hair,  
And in picturing you I may  
Scarcely go astray.

Oh, the vague reality!  
The mysterious certainty!  
Oh, strange truth of these my guesses  
In the wide thought-wildernesses!  
—Truth of one divined of many flowers;  
Of one raindrop in the showers  
Of the long ago swift rain;  
Of one tear of many tears  
In some world-renowned pain;  
Of one daisy 'mid the centuries of sun;  
Of a little living nun  
In the garden of the years.

Yes, I am not far astray;  
But I guess you as might one  
Pausing when young March is grey.  
In a violet-peopled day;  
All his thoughts go out to places that he knew,  
To his child-home in the sun,  
To the fields of his regret,  
To one place i' the innocent March air,  
By one olive, and invent  
The familiar form and scent

Safely; a white violet  
Certainly is there.

Soeur Monique, remember me.  
'Tis not in the past alone  
I am picturing you to be;  
But my little friend, my own,  
In my moment, pray for me.  
For another dream is mine,  
And another dream is true,  
Sweeter even,  
Of the little ones that shine  
Lost within the light divine,—  
Of some meekest flower, or you,  
In the fields of Heaven.



## SONNET.

Questo ne' patti nostri, Amor, non era.

LORENZO DE' MEDICI.

My heart shall be thy garden. Come, my own,  
Into thy garden; thine be happy hours  
Among my fairest thoughts, my tallest flowers,  
From root to crowning petal, thine alone.

Thine is the place from where the seeds are sown  
Up to the sky enclosed, with all its showers.  
But ah, the birds, the birds! Who shall build bowers  
To keep these thine? O friend, the birds have flown.

For as these come and go, and quit our pine  
To follow the sweet season, or, new-comers,  
Sing one song only from our alder-trees,

My heart has thoughts, which, though thine eyes hold mine,  
Flit to the silent world and other summers,  
With wings that dip beyond the silver seas.



## A TRYST THAT FAILED.

Ce pauvre temps passé!

ALFRED DE MUSSET.

It was a time of wind and sun,  
Morning day, and the Winter done,  
Morning life, and the Spring begun.

It was a place so dreamy and brown,  
Pensive with sheep-bells under the down,  
Scent-dreamy, wild, with a windy crown.

You were coming, out of the Spring,  
Out of the sun-dream wandering,  
Out of the wind-joy hastening.

I did not see you, sweet; a flight  
Of sea-birds only, pearly and white,  
With a sudden shadow fled into the light.

I never heard your call, my Fair;  
O music up in the flickering air!  
O voice my ears so ill could spare!

And the wild, wild call my soul begot,  
The long wild call, I know not what,—  
We met not then, for it reached you not,

And never again. But our hearts did greet.  
Whatever path misled your feet,

Voices so true could not but meet.

Though we have strayed from that place of heather,  
Your cry and mine speed on together  
Above the Spring and the Summer weather.

Among the stars and in the blue,  
What words could never my call may do,  
—Speak my love and loss of you.

# SONNET.

## THOUGHTS IN SEPARATION.

Plus loin que nos douleurs,  
Plus loin que nos murmures.

VICTOR HUGO.

We never meet; yet we meet day by day  
Upon those hills of life, dim and immense,  
The good we love, and sleep, our innocence.  
O hills of life, high hills! And higher than they.

Our guardian spirits meet at prayer and play.  
Beyond pain, joy, and hope, and long suspense,  
Above the summits of our souls, far hence,  
An angel meets an angel on the way.

Beyond all good I ever believed of thee  
Or thou of me, these always love and live.  
And though I fail of thy ideal of me,

My angel falls not short; they greet each other;  
Who knows, they may exchange the kiss we give,  
Thou to thy crucifix, I to my mother.



## REGRETS.

Amor, che a nullo amato amar perdona.

DANTE.

As when the seaward ebbing tide doth pour  
Out by the low sand spaces,  
The parting waves slip back to clasp the shore  
With lingering embraces;

So in the tide of life that carries me  
From where thy true heart dwells,  
Waves of my thoughts and memories turn to thee  
With lessening farewells;

Waving of hands; dreams, when the day forgets;  
A care half lost in cares;  
The saddest of my verses; dim regrets;  
Thy name among my prayers.

I would the day might come, so waited for,  
So patiently besought,  
When I, returning, should fill up once more  
Thy desolated thought;

And fill thy loneliness that lies apart  
In still, persistent pain.  
Shall I content thee, O thou broken heart,  
As the tide comes again,

And brims the little sea-shore lakes, and sets

Seaweeds afloat, and fills  
The silent pools, rivers and rivulets  
Among the inland hills?



## SONG.

My Fair, no beauty of thine will last,  
Save in my love's eternity.  
Thy smiles, that light thee fitfully,  
Are lost for ever—their moment past—  
Except the few thou givest to me.

Thy sweet words vanish day by day,  
As all breath of mortality;  
Thy laughter, done, must cease to be.  
And all thy dear tones pass away,  
Except the few that sing to me.

Hide then within my heart, oh, hide  
All thou art loth should go from thee.  
Be kinder to thyself and me.  
My cupfull from this river's tide  
Shall never reach the long sad sea.

**SONNET.**  
**IN FEBRUARY.**

Rich meanings of the prophet-Spring adorn,  
Unseen, this colourless sky of folded showers,  
And folded winds; no blossom in the bowers.  
A poet's face asleep is this grey morn.

Now in the midst of the old world forlorn  
A mystic child is set in these still hours.  
I keep this time, even before the flowers,  
Sacred to all the young and the unborn;

To all the miles and miles of unsprung wheat,  
And to the Spring waiting beyond the portal,  
And to the future of my own young art,

And, among all these things, to you, my sweet,  
My friend, to your calm face and the immortal  
Child tarrying all your life-time in your heart.



## SAN LORENZO GIUSTINIANI'S MOTHER.

And we the shadows of the dream.

SHELLEY.

I had not seen my son's dear face  
(He chose the cloister by God's grace)  
Since it had come to full flower-time.  
I hardly guessed at its perfect prime,  
That folded flower of his dear face.

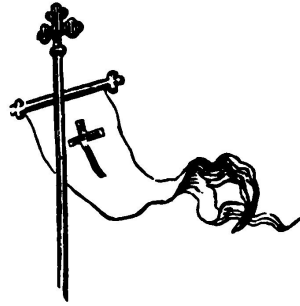
Mine eyes were veiled by mists of tears  
When on a day in many years  
One of his order came. I thrilled  
Facing, I thought, that face fulfilled.  
I doubted, for my mists of tears.

His blessing be with me for ever!  
My hope and doubt were hard to sever.  
—That altered face, those holy weeds.  
I filled his wallet and kissed his beads.  
And lost his echoing feet for ever.

If to my son my alms were given  
I know not, and I wait for Heaven.  
He did not plead for child of mine,  
But for another Child divine,  
And unto Him it was surely given.

There is one alone who cannot change;

Dreams are we, shadows, visions strange;  
And all I give is given to one.  
I might mistake my dearest son,  
But never the Son who cannot change.



## THE POETS.

**FIRST VOICE: THE ALPS. SECOND VOICE: THE ANGEL.**

Oh, for the hidden songs of showers,  
And symphonies of seas!  
Oh, for the secrets of a whispering wild of flowers,  
And guess'd accords of the harper-wind i' the trees,  
And the warm summer-bees.  
For us the springs are old,  
And summer after summer cold.  
For us the eagles scream  
Once suddenly in the sleep of snow.  
A deed is done among the centuries.  
An avalanche slides slow,  
And rests: one more eternity it lies:  
And there has been a fall across the dream  
Of the white sleep of snow.  
Our cold and crownéd heads are lifted up in woe,  
Our barren faces,  
Whose tears are sealed in awful places.  
Thou art so high above.  
Let be. A little life! a little love!  
What shall repay the baffled soul, the vain endeavour?  
Not our great nights  
Whose dark unmeasured windy mystery,  
Whose falls, whose heights  
No heart doth feel, no eye doth see,  
For ever.  
No, Lord, no.



Nor our great open secret snow,  
Where comes the sun at even and morn  
To be alone,  
And wild winds seeking solitude for their torn  
And wounded souls. Can these atone,  
Shall these repay?  
No, nor the dawns we know,  
Whose thoughts grow light on our eternal snow.  
We mourn, we pray:  
Oh, melt our snows to rain.  
How can we reach thee?  
Lay us low.  
Level us with the plain,  
Oh, we beseech thee.  
Second Voice:  
O cold and glorious!  
O lonely and victorious!  
Suffer your thoughts, abide.  
Suffer, ye seven-fold tried.  
Wild winds and storm, rejoice the peaks among;  
Exult with timbrel, dance, and song,  
Deafen that pain with jubilee.  
Cloud answers cloud with thunder;  
And eagle's voice to eagle's voice replies far under.  
I cannot let you be,  
My chosen, till your answer rise to me.  
Suffer your great wild things; abide.  
The secrets that in your abysses hide,  
And in your desolate cold are sealed,  
Gather in heaven and fall in tender rain  
That thoughts of many hearts may be revealed,  
These hearts that throng the plain.  
Over your brows shall clouds abide,  
Yours be the wildest winds, and vast suns open-eyed,  
And crowning mists that hide  
High fields of thoughts and sunlights after pain.  
First Voice:

How shall we reach thee?  
Level us with the plain,  
Oh, we beseech thee.

**SONNET.**  
**THE LOVE OF NARCISSUS.**

Like him who met his own eyes in the river,  
The poet trembles at his own long gaze  
That meets him through the changing nights and days  
From out great Nature; all her waters quiver

With his fair image facing him for ever;  
The music that he listens to betrays  
His own heart to his ears; by trackless ways  
His wild thoughts tend to him in long endeavour.

His dreams are for among the silent hills;  
His vague voice calls him from the darkened plain  
With winds at night; strange recognition thrills  
His lonely heart with piercing love and pain;  
He knows his sweet mirth in the mountain rills,  
His weary tears that touch him with the rain.

## TO A LOST MELODY.

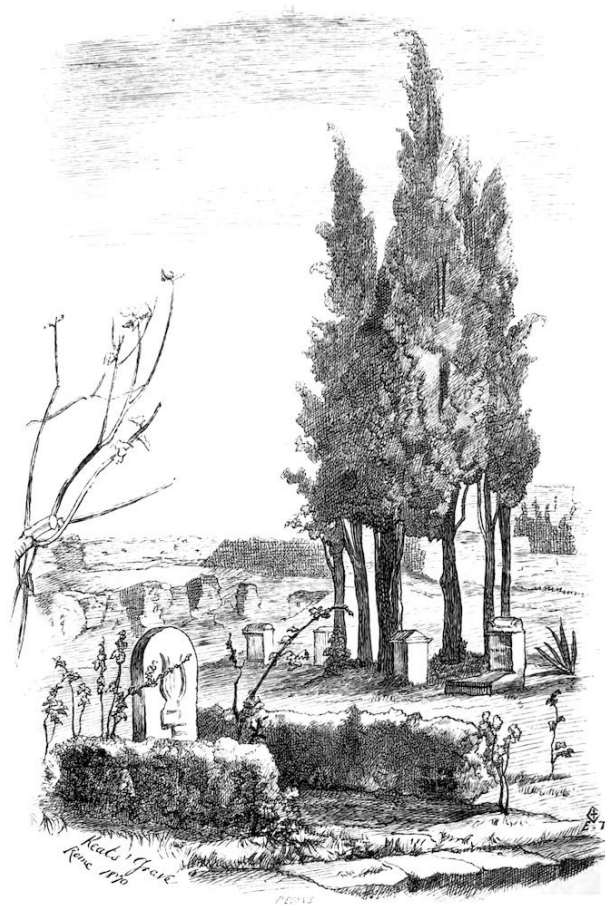
Ditties of no tone.

KEATS.

Thou art not dead, O sweet lost melody,  
    Sung beyond memory,  
When golden to the winds this world of ours  
    Waved wild with boundless flowers;  
Sung in some past when wildernesses were,—  
    Not dead, not dead, lost air!  
Yet in the ages long where lurkest thou,  
    And what soul knows thee now?  
Wert thou not given to sweeten every wind  
    From that o'erburdened mind  
That bore thee through the young world, and that tongue  
    By which thou first wert sung?  
Was not thy holy choir the endless dome,  
    And nature all thy home?  
Did not the warm gale clasp thee to his breast,  
    Lulling thy storms to rest?  
And is the June air laden with thee now,  
    Passing the summer-bough?  
And is the dawn-wind on a lonely sea  
    Balmy with thoughts of thee?  
To rock on daybreak winds dost thou rejoice,  
    As first on his strong voice  
Whose radiant morning soul did give thee birth,  
    Gave thee to heaven and earth?  
Or did each bird win one dear note of thee

To pipe eternally?  
Art thou the secret of the small field-flowers  
Nodding thy time for hours,  
—Blown by the happy winds from hill to hill,  
And such a secret still?  
Or wert thou rapt awhile to other spheres  
To gladden tenderer ears?  
Doth music's soul contain thee, precious air,  
Sleepest thou clasped there,  
Until a time shall come for thee to start  
Into some unborn heart?  
Then wilt thou as the clouds of ages roll,  
Thou migratory soul,  
Amid a different wilder wilderness  
—In crowds that throng and press,  
Revive thy blessed cadences forgotten  
In some soul new-begotten?  
Oh, wilt thou ever tire of thy long rest  
On nature's silent breast?  
And wilt thou leave thy rainbow showers, to bear  
A part in human care?  
—Forsake thy boundless silence to make choice  
Of some pathetic voice?  
—Forsake thy stars, thy suns, thy moons, thy skies,  
For man's desiring sighs?  
Ah, not for mine, who sit with empty ears,  
Dreaming of thee, to tears.





**SONNET.**  
**AT A POET'S GRAVE.**

Rather unto the Truth than unto one  
Who sleepeth here is raised this monument.  
To her he yields his tomb and is content.  
Ye living singers, shower and wind and sun,

Days, nights, and flowers obey your fancy's Art,  
And mean your meanings, elsewhere; they own.  
Here in this little sanctuary alone,  
Meanings beyond the deepest poet's heart.

Sing through the world; this is another world,  
This poet's empire, but he will not claim  
One flower sprung from his heart, nor ever steep  
One with his thoughts; his thoughts in truth are furled.  
There was no need of him; hush up his fame,  
Now earth has laid her docile child to sleep.

**SONNET.**  
**THE POET TO NATURE.**

Non tengo nascosto  
A te mio cor.

DANTE.

I have no secrets from thee, lyre sublime,  
My lyre whereof I make my melody.  
I sing one way like the west wind through thee,  
With my whole heart, and hear thy sweet strings chime.

But thou, who soundest in my tune and rhyme,  
Hast tones I wake not, in thy land and sea,  
Loveliness not for me, secrets from me,  
Thoughts for another, and another time.

And as, the west wind passed, the south wind alters  
His intimate sweet things, his hues of noon,  
The voices of his waves, sound of his pine,

The meanings of his lost heart,—this thought falters  
In my short song—“Another bard shall tune  
Thee, O my Lyre, to other songs than mine.”



## THE POET TO HIS CHILDHOOD.

Que vous ai-je donc fait, ô mes jeunes années!

VICTOR HUGO.

In my thought I see you stand with a path on either hand,  
—Hills that look into the sun, and there a river'd meadow-land.  
And your lost voice with the things that it decreed across me thrills,  
When you thought, and chose the hills.

“If it prove a life of pain, greater have I judged the gain.  
With a singing soul for music's sake, I climb and meet the rain,  
And I choose, whilst I am calm, my thought and labouring to be  
Unconsoled by sympathy.”

But how dared you use me so? For you bring my ripe years low  
To your child's whim and a destiny your child-soul could not know.  
And that small voice legislating I revolt against, with tears.  
But you mark not, through the years.

“To the mountain leads my way. If the plains are green to-day,  
These my barren hills are flushing faintly, strangely in the May,  
With the presence of the Spring amongst the smallest flowers that  
grow.”

But the summer in the snow?

Do you know, who are so bold, how in sooth the rule will hold,  
Settled by a wayward child's ideal at some ten years old?  
—How the human arms you slip from, thoughts and love you stay not  
for,

Will not open to you more?

You were rash then, little child, for the skies with storms are wild,  
And you faced the dim horizon with its whirl of mists, and smiled,  
Climbed a little higher, lonelier, in the solitary sun,  
To feel how the winds came on.

But your sunny silence there, solitude so light to bear,  
Will become a long dumb world up in the colder sadder air,  
And the little mournful lonelinesses in the little hills  
Wider wilderness fulfils.

And if e'er you should come down to the village or the town,  
With the cold rain for your garland, and the wind for your renown,  
You will stand upon the thresholds with a face of dumb desire,  
Nor be known by any fire.

It is memory that shrinks. You were all too brave, methinks,  
Climbing solitudes of flowering cistus and the thin wild pinks,  
Musing, setting to a haunting air in one vague reverie  
All the life that was to be.

With a smile do I complain in the safety of the pain,  
Knowing that my feet can never quit their solitudes again;  
But regret may turn with longing to that one hour's choice you had,  
For the silence is so sad.

I rebel *not*, child gone by, but obey you wonderingly,  
For you knew not, young rash speaker, all you spoke, and now will I,  
With the life, and all the loneliness revealed that you thought fit,  
Sing the Amen, knowing it.

**SONNET.**  
**TO —.**

Com' a te piace  
Parla.

DANTE.

Thou poet of one mood in all thy lays,  
Who rangest all life with one only love,  
Like a west wind across the world dost move,  
Sweeping thy harp of floods thine own wild ways.

The countries change, but not the west-wind days  
Which are thy songs. Thy soft skies shine above,  
And on all seas the colours of a dove,  
And on all fields a flash of silver greys.

So make the whole world answer to thy art,  
And sweet monotonous meanings; charm our ears;  
Change not thou ever, bearing, for thy part,  
One thought that is the treasure of thy years,  
A small cloud full of rain upon thy heart  
And in thine arms, clasped, like a child in tears.

## AN UNMARKED FESTIVAL.

Benedetto sia'l giorno e'l mese e l'anno.

PETRARCA.

There's a feast, undated, yet  
Both our true lives hold it fast,—  
The first day we ever met.  
What a great day came and passed!  
—Unknown then, but known at last.

And we met; you knew not me,  
Mistress of your joys and fears;  
Held my hand that held the key  
Of the treasure of your years,  
Of the fountain of your tears.

For you knew not it was I,  
And I knew not it was you.  
We have learnt, as days went by.  
But a flower struck root and grew  
Underground, and no one knew.

Day of days! Unmarked it rose,  
In whose hours we were to meet,  
And forgotten passed. Who knows,  
Was earth cold, or sunny, sweet,  
At the coming of your feet?

One mere day, we thought; the measure

Of such days the year fulfils.  
Now, how dearly would we treasure  
Something from its fields, its rills,  
And its memorable hills;

—But one leaf of oak or lime,  
Or one blossom from its bowers  
No one gathered at the time.  
Oh, to keep that day of ours  
By one relic of its flowers!



# SONNET.

## A YOUNG CONVERT.

Mio cor in sul fiorire e in sul far frutto.

PETRARCA.

Who knows what days I answer for to-day?  
Giving the bud I give the flower. I bow  
This yet unfaded and a faded brow;  
Bending these knees and feeble knees, I pray.  
Thoughts yet unripe in me I bend one way,  
Give one repose to pain I know not now,  
One leaven to joy that comes, I guess not how.  
Oh, rash! (I smile) as one, when Spring is grey,  
Who dedicates a land of hidden wheat.  
I fold to-day at altars far apart  
Hands trembling with what toils? In their retreat  
I sign my love to come, my folded art.  
I light the tapers at my head and feet,  
And lay the crucifix on this silent heart.

**SONNET.**  
**SPRING ON THE ALBAN HILLS.**  
**TO —.**

Silent with expectation.

SHELLEY.

O'er the Campagna it is dim warm weather;  
The Spring comes with a full heart silently,  
And many thoughts; a faint flash of the sea  
Divides two mists; straight falls the falling feather.

With wild Spring meanings hill and plain together  
Grow pale, or just flush with a dust of flowers.  
Rome in the ages, dimmed with all her towers,  
Floats in the midst, a little cloud at tether.

I fain would put my hands about thy face,  
Thou with thy thoughts, who art another Spring,  
And draw thee to me like a mournful child.

Thou lookest on me from another place;  
I touch not this day's secret, nor the thing  
That in thy silence makes thy sweet eyes wild.





## SONG OF THE NIGHT AT DAYBREAK.

Night hovers all day in the boughs.

EMERSON.

All my stars forsake me,  
And the dawn-winds shake me.  
Where shall I betake me?

Whither shall I run  
Till the set of sun,  
Till the day be done?

To the mountain-mine,  
To the boughs o' the pine,  
To the blind man's eyne.

To a brow that is  
Bowed upon the knees,  
Sick with memories.

**SONNET.**  
**TO A DAISY.**

Slight as thou art, thou art enough to hide,  
Like all created things, secrets from me,  
And stand a barrier to eternity.  
And I, how can I praise thee well and wide

From where I dwell—upon the hither side?  
Thou little veil for so great mystery,  
When shall I penetrate all things and thee,  
And then look back? For this I must abide,

Till thou shalt grow and fold and be unfurled  
Literally between me and the world.  
Then I shall drink from in beneath a spring,

And from a poet's side shall read his book.  
O daisy mine, what will it be to look  
From God's side even of such a simple thing?

**SONNET.**  
**TO ONE POEM IN A SILENT TIME.**

De quel nom te nommer?

VICTOR HUGO.

Who looked for thee, thou little song of mine?  
This winter of a silent poet's heart  
Is suddenly sweet with thee, but what thou art,  
Mid-winter flower, I would I could divine.

Art thou a last one, orphan of thy line?  
Did the dead summer's last warmth foster thee?  
Or is Spring folded up unguessed in me,  
And stirring out of sight,—and thou the sign?

Where shall I look—backwards or to the morrow  
For others of thy fragrance, secret child?  
Who knows if last things or if first things claim thee?

—Whether thou be the last smile of my sorrow,  
Or else a joy too sweet, a joy too wild?  
How, my December violet, shall I name thee?

# **A STUDY:**

## **IN THREE MONOLOGUES, WITH INTERRUPTIONS.**

### **I.**

#### **BEFORE LIGHT.**

Among the first to wake. What wakes with me?  
A blind wind and a few birds and a star.  
With tremor of darkened flowers and whisper of birds,  
Oh, with a tremor, with a tremor of heart—  
Begins the day i' the dark. I, newly waked,  
Grove backwards for my dreams, thinking to slide  
Back unawares to dreams, in vain, in vain.  
There is a sorrow for me in this day.  
It watched me from afar the livelong night,  
And now draws near, but has not touched me yet.  
In from my garden flits the secret wind,—  
My garden.—This great day with all its hours  
(Its hours, my soul!) will be like other days  
Among my flowers. The morning will awake,  
Like to the lonely waking of a child  
Who grows uneasily to a sense of tears,  
Because his mother had come and wept and gone;  
The morning grass and lilies will be wet,  
In all their happiness, with mysterious dews.  
And I shall leave the high noon in my garden,  
The sun enthroned and all his court my flowers,  
And go my journey as I live,—alone.  
Then in the ripe rays of the later day

All the small blades of thin grass one by one,  
Looked through with sun, will make each a long shade,  
And daisies' heads will bend with butterflies.  
And one will come with secrets at her heart,  
Evening, whose darkening eyes hide all her heart,  
And poppy-crowned move 'mid my lonely flowers.  
And shall another, I wonder, come with her,—  
I, with a heavy secret at my heart,  
Uncrowned of all crowns to my garden and flowers?  
Thou little home of mine, fair be thy day.  
These things will be, but oh, across the hills,  
Behind me in the dark, what things will be?  
—Well, even if sorrow fills me through and through  
Until my life be pain and pain my life,  
Shall I not bear myself and my own life?  
—A little life, O Lord, a little sorrow.  
And I remember once when I was ill  
That the whole world seemed breaking through with me,  
Who lay so light and still; stillness availed not,  
My weakness being a thing of power, I thought.

“Come to the Port to-morrow,” says the letter,  
And little more, except a few calm words,  
Intended to prepare me (and I guess,  
I guess for what). He never was too kind,  
This man, the one i' the world, kin to my son,  
Who knew my crime, who watched me with cold eyes,  
And stayed me with calm hands, and hid the thing,  
For horror more than pity; and took my son;  
And mercifully let me ebb away  
In this grey town of undesigned grey lives,  
Five years already. To-day he sends for me.  
And now I will prevent the dawn with prayers.





## II. ABOUT NOON.

She shut her five years up within the house.  
And towards the noon she lifted up her eyes,  
Looked to the gentle hills with a stirred heart,  
Moved with the mystery of unknown places  
Near to a long-known home; smiled, as she could,  
A difficult smile that hurt half of her mouth,  
Until she passed the streets and all sharp looks.

“Sharp looks, and since I was a child, sharp looks!  
These know not, certainly, who scan me so,  
That not a girl of all their brightest girls  
Has such an eager heart for smiles as I.  
It is no doubt the fault of my cold face  
And reticent eyes that never make appeal,  
Or plead for the small pale bewildered soul.  
If they but knew what a poor child I am!  
—Oh, born of all the past, what a poor child!  
I could waste golden days and showers of words,  
And laugh for nothing, and read my poets again,  
And tend a voice I had, songless for ever;—  
I would not if I might. I would not cease,  
No if I might, the penance and the pain  
For that lost soul down somewhere in the past,  
That soul of mine that did and knew such things  
If I could choose; and yet I wish, I wish,  
Such little wishes, and so longingly.  
Who would believe me, knowing what I am?

“Now from these noontide hills my home, my time,  
My life for years lies underneath mine eyes,  
And all the years that led up to these years.  
I can judge now, and not the world for me.

And I, being what I am, and having done  
What I have done, look back upon my youth  
—Before my crime, I mean,—and testify:  
It was not happy, no, it was not white,  
It was not innocent, no, the young fair time.  
The people and the years passed in my glass;  
And all the insincerity of my thoughts  
I laid upon the pure and simple Nature  
(Now all the hills and fields are free of me),  
Smiling at my elaborate sigh the smile  
Of any Greek composing sunny gods.  
And now begins my one true white child-time,  
This time of desolate altars and all ruins.  
For Pan is dead and the altars are in ruins.

“The world is full of endings for me, I find,  
Emotions lost, and words and thoughts forgotten.  
Yet amid all these *last* things, there is one,  
But one Beginning, a seed within my soul.  
Come quickly! and go by quickly, O my years!  
Strip me of things and thoughts; as I have seen  
The ilex changing leaves; for day by day  
A little innocent life grows in my life,  
A little ignorant life i’ the world-worn life;  
And I become a child with a world to learn,  
Timorous, with another world to learn,  
Timorous, younger, whiter towards my death.”

She turned to the strange sea that five long years  
Had sent her letters of his misty winds,  
Bearing a cry of storms in other lands,  
And songs of mariners singing over seas;  
And having long conjectured of his face,  
Seeing his face, paused, thinking of the past.  
Down the hills came she to the town and sea,  
And met her child’s friend where he waited her.  
She swayed to his words unsaid, as the green canes



Murmur i' the quiet unto a wind that comes:

“I sent for you, mind, for your sake alone.  
—No, my dear ward is well. But it has chanced  
(I know it's a hard thing for you to bear,  
But you are strong, I know) that he has learnt  
What I had faithfully kept,—your life, your past,  
Your secret. Well, we hope that you repent,  
At least, your son and I.”

“God bless my son,  
My little son hopes I repent at least.”

“When he had read the papers—by mischance—  
I would have kept them from him, broken down,  
Beside myself at first, though the young heart  
Recovered and is calm now, he resolved  
On the completest parting; for he thinks  
He could not live under one sky with you.  
But being unwilling to disturb you now  
And vex you in your harmless life, gives up  
His hopes in England, his career, and sails  
To-night to make a new life in the States.  
As to the question of your seeing him  
(He is in the town here), I persuaded him  
To let you choose, this being probably  
The last time in this world. It rests with you.”

“I pray you, as we pray morning and night,  
Save me from the sick eyes of my one child;  
But let me see my one child once. Amen.

“I never came across the hills before  
In all these years; now all these years are done.  
Who would have said it, yesterday at this hour?  
Now my son knows, and I have crossed the hills,  
And sure my poor face faces other things.  
Not back! not home! anything, anything,

Anything—no, don't turn, I am very calm.  
Not back the way I came to-day, not home.  
Oh, anything but home and a long life."

"Am I the arbiter? Besides, what fate  
Can you desire more merciful than home  
And hidden life? And then remember him.  
You have borne the separation as it seems  
With the most perfect patience. And your life  
Ending (as to the world), owes this at least—  
It is not much—to his bright beginning life,  
Absence and perfect silence till you die.  
I've done my duty, as I think, to both.  
If you seemed in the least to ask for pity  
I well could pity you. I hope that time  
Will bring you a softer heart. Good-bye."

"Good-bye."

### III. AT TWILIGHT.

Gone, O my child forsaking me, my flower.  
Yet I forsaken pity you with tears,  
Gone while I learn a world to learn a world.  
I am to have no part with you again,  
And you have many things to share; it's keen,—  
I love you, I love you; but more keen is this,—  
That you will have no part with me again;  
And what have I to share? Pain, happy child.  
Gone, gone into the west, for ever gone,  
O little one, my flower; not you alone,  
My son who are leaving me, but he, the child  
Of five years back. That is the worst farewell.  
I had not thought him lost until to-day.  
But he had kept with me until to-day;—  
Never seen, never heard; but he was there,  
Behind the door on which I laid my hand,  
Out in the garden when I sat within,  
A turn of road before me in my walks.  
As others greet a presence I did greet  
An absence, O my sweet, my sweet surprise!  
How will it be now? for he is so changed  
I hardly knew the face I saw pass by.  
And yet it is the one that must of needs  
Grow from that long ago face innocent,  
Grave with the presage of a human life.  
So, child, giving again in thought my kiss,  
My last, long since, I kiss you tall and changed  
In that one kiss, and kiss you a man and old,  
And so I kiss you dead. And yet, O child,  
O child, a certain soul goes from my days;  
They fall together like a rosary told,  
Not aves now, but beads,—you being gone.

I was not worthy to be comfortless,  
I find; and feasts broke in upon my fasts;  
And innocent distractions and desires  
Surprised me in my penitential tears.  
For my absent child God gives me a child in Spring;  
New seasons and the fresh and innocent earth,  
Ever new years and children of the years,  
Kin to the young thoughts of my weary heart,  
Chime with the young thoughts of my weary heart,  
My kin in all the world. And He Himself  
Is young in the quiet time of cold and snows.  
(Mary! who fledst to Egypt with Him; Joseph!  
And thou whose tomb I kissed in Padua,  
Protect this perilous childhood in my heart!)  
But oh, to-night, I know not why, to-night  
Out of the earth and sky, out of the sea  
My consolations fade. These empty arms  
I stretch no more unto the beautiful world,  
But clasp them close about the lonely heart  
No other arms will clasp. What is thy pain,  
What is thy pain, inexplicable heart?  
Sorrow for ruined and for desolate days.  
Failing in penitence, I, who fail in all,  
Leave all my thoughts alone, and lift mine eyes  
Quietly to One who makes amends for me.  
Peace, O my soul, for thou hast failed in all:  
(One thought, at last, that I might take to Heaven!)

It's well I never guessed this thing before,—  
I mean the weakness and the littleness  
Of that which by God's grace begins in me.  
Oh, earthly hopes and wishes, stay with me  
(He will be patient); linger, O my loves  
And phases of myself, and play with this  
New life of grace (as He whose gift it is  
Played with the children, a child). How could I bear  
To see how little is perfect yet—a speck

If all things else should suddenly wither away?  
(And yet they wither away, they wither away.)  
Less than I knew, less than I know am I,  
Returning childless, but, O Father, a child.

She therefore turned unto the Eastern hills,  
Thrilled with a west wind sowing stars. She saw  
Her lonely upward way climb to the verge  
And ending of the day-time; and she knew  
The downward way in presence of the night.  
She heard the fitful sheep-bells in the glen  
Move like a child's thoughts. There she felt the earth  
Lonely in space. And all things suddenly  
Shook with her tears. She went with shadowless feet,  
Moving along the shadow of the world,  
Faring alone to home and a long life,  
Setting her twilight face to meet the stars.



NOTE.

*I have borrowed the metre of one of the pieces in this volume—a stanza of three verses rhyming disyllabically—from a beautiful poem by Mr. Oliver Wendell Holmes.*

UNWIN BROTHERS, THE GRESHAM PRESS, CHILWORTH AND LONDON.



## **TRANSCRIBER'S NOTES**

- Fixed typos; non-standard spelling and dialect retained.

\*\*\* END OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK PRELUDES \*\*\*

Updated editions will replace the previous one—the old editions will be renamed.

Creating the works from print editions not protected by U.S. copyright law means that no one owns a United States copyright in these works, so the Foundation (and you!) can copy and distribute it in the United States without permission and without paying copyright royalties. Special rules, set forth in the General Terms of Use part of this license, apply to copying and distributing Project Gutenberg™ electronic works to protect the PROJECT GUTENBERG™ concept and trademark. Project Gutenberg is a registered trademark, and may not be used if you charge for an eBook, except by following the terms of the trademark license, including paying royalties for use of the Project Gutenberg trademark. If you do not charge anything for copies of this eBook, complying with the trademark license is very easy. You may use this eBook for nearly any purpose such as creation of derivative works, reports, performances and research. Project Gutenberg eBooks may be modified and printed and given away—you may do practically ANYTHING in the United States with eBooks not protected by U.S. copyright law. Redistribution is subject to the trademark license, especially commercial redistribution.

START: FULL LICENSE



# THE FULL PROJECT GUTENBERG™ LICENSE

PLEASE READ THIS BEFORE YOU DISTRIBUTE OR USE THIS WORK

To protect the Project Gutenberg™ mission of promoting the free distribution of electronic works, by using or distributing this work (or any other work associated in any way with the phrase “Project Gutenberg”), you agree to comply with all the terms of the Full Project Gutenberg License available with this file or online at [www.gutenberg.org/license](http://www.gutenberg.org/license).

## **Section 1. General Terms of Use and Redistributing Project Gutenberg electronic works**

1.A. By reading or using any part of this Project Gutenberg electronic work, you indicate that you have read, understand, agree to and accept all the terms of this license and intellectual property (trademark/copyright) agreement. If you do not agree to abide by all the terms of this agreement, you must cease using and return or destroy all copies of Project Gutenberg electronic works in your possession. If you paid a fee for obtaining a copy of or access to a Project Gutenberg electronic work and you do not agree to be bound by the terms of this agreement, you may obtain a refund from the person or entity to whom you paid the fee as set forth in paragraph 1.E.8.

1.B. “Project Gutenberg” is a registered trademark. It may only be used on or associated in any way with an electronic work by people who agree to be bound by the terms of this agreement. There are a few things that you can do with most Project Gutenberg electronic works even without complying with the full terms of this agreement. See paragraph 1.C below. There are a lot of things you can do with Project Gutenberg electronic works if you follow the terms of this agreement and help preserve free future access to Project Gutenberg electronic works. See paragraph 1.E below.

1.C. The Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation (“the Foundation” or PGLAF), owns a compilation copyright in the

collection of Project Gutenberg electronic works. Nearly all the individual works in the collection are in the public domain in the United States. If an individual work is unprotected by copyright law in the United States and you are located in the United States, we do not claim a right to prevent you from copying, distributing, performing, displaying or creating derivative works based on the work as long as all references to Project Gutenberg are removed. Of course, we hope that you will support the Project Gutenberg mission of promoting free access to electronic works by freely sharing Project Gutenberg works in compliance with the terms of this agreement for keeping the Project Gutenberg name associated with the work. You can easily comply with the terms of this agreement by keeping this work in the same format with its attached full Project Gutenberg License when you share it without charge with others.

1.D. The copyright laws of the place where you are located also govern what you can do with this work. Copyright laws in most countries are in a constant state of change. If you are outside the United States, check the laws of your country in addition to the terms of this agreement before downloading, copying, displaying, performing, distributing or creating derivative works based on this work or any other Project Gutenberg work. The Foundation makes no representations concerning the copyright status of any work in any country other than the United States.

1.E. Unless you have removed all references to Project Gutenberg:

1.E.1. The following sentence, with active links to, or other immediate access to, the full Project Gutenberg License must appear prominently whenever any copy of a Project Gutenberg work (any work on which the phrase “Project Gutenberg” appears, or with which the phrase “Project Gutenberg” is associated) is accessed, displayed, performed, viewed, copied or distributed:

This eBook is for the use of anyone anywhere in the United States and most other parts of the world at no cost and with almost no restrictions whatsoever. You may copy it, give it away or re-use it under the terms of the Project Gutenberg™ License included with this eBook or online at [www.gutenberg.org](http://www.gutenberg.org). If you are not located in the United States, you will have to check the laws of the country where you are located before using this eBook.

1.E.2. If an individual Project Gutenberg electronic work is derived from texts not protected by U.S. copyright law (does not contain a notice indicating that it is posted with permission of the copyright holder), the work can be copied and distributed to anyone in the United States without paying any fees or charges. If you are redistributing or providing access to a work with the phrase “Project Gutenberg” associated with or appearing on the work, you must comply either with the requirements of paragraphs 1.E.1 through 1.E.7 or obtain permission for the use of the work and the Project Gutenberg trademark as set forth in paragraphs 1.E.8 or 1.E.9.

1.E.3. If an individual Project Gutenberg electronic work is posted with the permission of the copyright holder, your use and distribution must comply with both paragraphs 1.E.1 through 1.E.7 and any additional terms imposed by the copyright holder. Additional terms will be linked to the Project Gutenberg License for all works posted with the permission of the copyright holder found at the beginning of this work.

1.E.4. Do not unlink or detach or remove the full Project Gutenberg License terms from this work, or any files containing a part of this work or any other work associated with Project Gutenberg.

1.E.5. Do not copy, display, perform, distribute or redistribute this electronic work, or any part of this electronic work, without prominently displaying the sentence set forth in paragraph 1.E.1 with active links or immediate access to the full terms of the Project Gutenberg License.

1.E.6. You may convert to and distribute this work in any binary, compressed, marked up, nonproprietary or proprietary form, including any word processing or hypertext form. However, if you provide access to or distribute copies of a Project Gutenberg work in a format other than “Plain Vanilla ASCII” or other format used in the official version posted on the official Project Gutenberg website ([www.gutenberg.org](http://www.gutenberg.org)), you must, at no additional cost, fee or expense to the user, provide a copy, a means of exporting a copy, or a means of obtaining a copy upon request, of the work in its original “Plain

Vanilla ASCII” or other form. Any alternate format must include the full Project Gutenberg License as specified in paragraph 1.E.1.

1.E.7. Do not charge a fee for access to, viewing, displaying, performing, copying or distributing any Project Gutenberg works unless you comply with paragraph 1.E.8 or 1.E.9.

1.E.8. You may charge a reasonable fee for copies of or providing access to or distributing Project Gutenberg electronic works provided that:

- You pay a royalty fee of 20% of the gross profits you derive from the use of Project Gutenberg works calculated using the method you already use to calculate your applicable taxes. The fee is owed to the owner of the Project Gutenberg trademark, but he has agreed to donate royalties under this paragraph to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation. Royalty payments must be paid within 60 days following each date on which you prepare (or are legally required to prepare) your periodic tax returns. Royalty payments should be clearly marked as such and sent to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation at the address specified in Section 4, “Information about donations to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation.”
- You provide a full refund of any money paid by a user who notifies you in writing (or by e-mail) within 30 days of receipt that s/he does not agree to the terms of the full Project Gutenberg™ License. You must require such a user to return or destroy all copies of the works possessed in a physical medium and discontinue all use of and all access to other copies of Project Gutenberg™ works.
- You provide, in accordance with paragraph 1.F.3, a full refund of any money paid for a work or a replacement copy, if a defect in the electronic work is discovered and reported to you within 90 days of receipt of the work.
- You comply with all other terms of this agreement for free distribution of Project Gutenberg™ works.

1.E.9. If you wish to charge a fee or distribute a Project Gutenberg™ electronic work or group of works on different terms than are set forth in this agreement, you must obtain permission in writing from the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation, the manager of the Project Gutenberg™ trademark. Contact the Foundation as set forth in Section 3 below.

1.F.

1.F.1. Project Gutenberg volunteers and employees expend considerable effort to identify, do copyright research on, transcribe and proofread works not protected by U.S. copyright law in creating the Project Gutenberg™ collection. Despite these efforts, Project Gutenberg™ electronic works, and the medium on which they may be stored, may contain “Defects,” such as, but not limited to, incomplete, inaccurate or corrupt data, transcription errors, a copyright or other intellectual property infringement, a defective or damaged disk or other medium, a computer virus, or computer codes that damage or cannot be read by your equipment.

1.F.2. LIMITED WARRANTY, DISCLAIMER OF DAMAGES - Except for the “Right of Replacement or Refund” described in paragraph 1.F.3, the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation, the owner of the Project Gutenberg™ trademark, and any other party distributing a Project Gutenberg™ electronic work under this agreement, disclaim all liability to you for damages, costs and expenses, including legal fees. YOU AGREE THAT YOU HAVE NO REMEDIES FOR NEGLIGENCE, STRICT LIABILITY, BREACH OF WARRANTY OR BREACH OF CONTRACT EXCEPT THOSE PROVIDED IN PARAGRAPH 1.F.3. YOU AGREE THAT THE FOUNDATION, THE TRADEMARK OWNER, AND ANY DISTRIBUTOR UNDER THIS AGREEMENT WILL NOT BE LIABLE TO YOU FOR ACTUAL, DIRECT, INDIRECT, CONSEQUENTIAL, PUNITIVE OR INCIDENTAL DAMAGES EVEN IF YOU GIVE NOTICE OF THE POSSIBILITY OF SUCH DAMAGE.

1.F.3. LIMITED RIGHT OF REPLACEMENT OR REFUND - If you discover a defect in this electronic work within 90 days of receiving it, you can receive a refund of the money (if any) you paid for it by sending a written explanation to the person you received the work from. If you received the work on a physical medium, you must return the medium with your written explanation. The person or entity that provided you with the defective work may elect to provide a replacement copy in lieu of a refund. If you received the work electronically, the person or entity providing it to you may choose to give you a second opportunity to receive the work electronically in lieu of a refund. If the second copy is also defective, you may demand a refund in writing without further opportunities to fix the problem.

1.F.4. Except for the limited right of replacement or refund set forth in paragraph 1.F.3, this work is provided to you 'AS-IS', WITH NO OTHER WARRANTIES OF ANY KIND, EXPRESS OR IMPLIED, INCLUDING BUT NOT LIMITED TO WARRANTIES OF MERCHANTABILITY OR FITNESS FOR ANY PURPOSE.

1.F.5. Some states do not allow disclaimers of certain implied warranties or the exclusion or limitation of certain types of damages. If any disclaimer or limitation set forth in this agreement violates the law of the state applicable to this agreement, the agreement shall be interpreted to make the maximum disclaimer or limitation permitted by the applicable state law. The invalidity or unenforceability of any provision of this agreement shall not void the remaining provisions.

1.F.6. INDEMNITY - You agree to indemnify and hold the Foundation, the trademark owner, any agent or employee of the Foundation, anyone providing copies of Project Gutenberg™ electronic works in accordance with this agreement, and any volunteers associated with the production, promotion and distribution of Project Gutenberg™ electronic works, harmless from all liability, costs and expenses, including legal fees, that arise directly or indirectly from any of the following which you do or cause to occur: (a) distribution of this or any Project Gutenberg work, (b) alteration,

modification, or additions or deletions to any Project Gutenberg work, and (c) any Defect you cause.

## **Section 2. Information about the Mission of Project Gutenberg**

Project Gutenberg is synonymous with the free distribution of electronic works in formats readable by the widest variety of computers including obsolete, old, middle-aged and new computers. It exists because of the efforts of hundreds of volunteers and donations from people in all walks of life.

Volunteers and financial support to provide volunteers with the assistance they need are critical to reaching Project Gutenberg's goals and ensuring that the Project Gutenberg collection will remain freely available for generations to come. In 2001, the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation was created to provide a secure and permanent future for Project Gutenberg and future generations. To learn more about the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation and how your efforts and donations can help, see Sections 3 and 4 and the Foundation information page at [www.gutenberg.org](http://www.gutenberg.org).

## **Section 3. Information about the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation**

The Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation is a non-profit 501(c)(3) educational corporation organized under the laws of the state of Mississippi and granted tax exempt status by the Internal Revenue Service. The Foundation's EIN or federal tax identification number is 64-6221541. Contributions to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation are tax deductible to the full extent permitted by U.S. federal laws and your state's laws.

The Foundation's business office is located at 41 Watchung Plaza #516, Montclair NJ 07042, USA, +1 (862) 621-9288. Email contact links and up to date contact information can be found at the Foundation's website and official page at [www.gutenberg.org/contact](http://www.gutenberg.org/contact)

## **Section 4. Information about Donations to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation**

Project Gutenberg™ depends upon and cannot survive without widespread public support and donations to carry out its mission of increasing the number of public domain and licensed works that can be freely distributed in machine-readable form accessible by the widest array of equipment including outdated equipment. Many small donations (\$1 to \$5,000) are particularly important to maintaining tax exempt status with the IRS.

The Foundation is committed to complying with the laws regulating charities and charitable donations in all 50 states of the United States. Compliance requirements are not uniform and it takes a considerable effort, much paperwork and many fees to meet and keep up with these requirements. We do not solicit donations in locations where we have not received written confirmation of compliance. To SEND DONATIONS or determine the status of compliance for any particular state visit [www.gutenberg.org/donate](http://www.gutenberg.org/donate).

While we cannot and do not solicit contributions from states where we have not met the solicitation requirements, we know of no prohibition against accepting unsolicited donations from donors in such states who approach us with offers to donate.

International donations are gratefully accepted, but we cannot make any statements concerning tax treatment of donations received from outside the United States. U.S. laws alone swamp our small staff.

Please check the Project Gutenberg web pages for current donation methods and addresses. Donations are accepted in a number of other ways including checks, online payments and credit card donations. To donate, please visit: [www.gutenberg.org/donate](http://www.gutenberg.org/donate).

## **Section 5. General Information About Project Gutenberg electronic works**



Professor Michael S. Hart was the originator of the Project Gutenberg concept of a library of electronic works that could be freely shared with anyone. For forty years, he produced and distributed Project Gutenberg eBooks with only a loose network of volunteer support.

Project Gutenberg eBooks are often created from several printed editions, all of which are confirmed as not protected by copyright in the U.S. unless a copyright notice is included. Thus, we do not necessarily keep eBooks in compliance with any particular paper edition.

Most people start at our website which has the main PG search facility: [www.gutenberg.org](http://www.gutenberg.org).

This website includes information about Project Gutenberg, including how to make donations to the Project Gutenberg Literary Archive Foundation, how to help produce our new eBooks, and how to subscribe to our email newsletter to hear about new eBooks.